

The Weight of the Room: A Narrative Inquiry into the Perceived Culture of Strength Training

Spaces Among Perimenopausal Women

SRM 680: Introduction to Qualitative Research

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Abstract

This qualitative, narrative inquiry, study examines the intersection of mid-life physiological changes and the social architecture of strength training. As perimenopausal women increasingly turn to strength training for its documented physical and psychological benefits, the specific unspoken rules and sensory cultures of these spaces remain largely unexplored. The physical and psychological effects of perimenopause can cause feelings of loss of identity, lack of control, and grief for a life and body that no longer feels like theirs. This research employs a narrative inquiry approach to explore the lived experiences of women practicing strength training as they navigate gym environments often dominated by conventional masculine norms. Through semi-structured interviews, 7 participants shared their experiences of starting weightlifting and how gym culture influenced their sense of self and ability to cope with their new perimenopausal experiences. The data was analyzed with narrative thematic analysis to identify patterns that can influence gym owners, fitness professionals, and healthcare professionals to better support women during this transition.

Keywords: narrative inquiry, perimenopause, strength training, body comparison, gym culture

Trustworthiness

Triangulation, originally proposed by Denzin (1978), was the primary method of trustworthiness used in this study. Of Denzin's four proposed types, we used multiple sources of data and multiple investigators (1978). The use of multiple sources of data is described by Merriam & Tisdell as encompassing the collection of data from people with different perspectives (2015, p. 220). We addressed this in our study by interviewing seven women from different backgrounds, ethnicities, and socio-economic conditions.

Further, we incorporated "triangulating analysts – that is, having two or more persons independently analyze the same qualitative data and compare their findings" (Patton, 2015, p. 665). We each collected and analyzed our own interviews. Following this, we each reviewed and analyzed one of the interviews taken by each of the other researchers and compared our findings. Further, we discussed codes and theme identification as a group. Asking each other for feedback helped cover any gaps we missed as individuals. Our example code book, after discussion and comparison, is in Appendix D. To further ensure that "the results are consistent with the data collected" (Merriam & Tisdell, 2015, p. 225) we developed spectra of themes to incorporate dissonant viewpoints resulting from variations among participants.

All identifying information, such as names or specific gym locations, were replaced with pseudonyms. Recordings and transcripts were stored in password-protected electronic files accessible only to the primary investigating team. Any direct quotes were edited to mask unique demographic details that could inadvertently reveal a participant's identity.

The Weight of the Room: A Qualitative Inquiry into the Perceived Culture of Strength Training Spaces Among Perimenopausal Women

The transition into perimenopause involves a complex mix of physical and emotional changes that can significantly alter a woman's relationship with her body. For many women in their 40s and 50s, the transition into perimenopause is described as a 'hormonal maelstrom' where the 'body doesn't look, feel or behave like yours anymore' (Sims, 2022). Research shows that during this stage, women may experience "anabolic resistance," a condition where the body becomes less efficient at using protein for muscle repair, making heavy resistance training a biological necessity rather than just a lifestyle choice (Sims, 2022). Additionally, bone density can decline by as much as 20% within the first five to seven years of this transition, and muscle mass loss speeds up considerably during this time (Sweat, 2025). High-intensity resistance training has proven to be the most effective method for maintaining bone mineral density and physical function in postmenopausal women (Watson et al., 2018).

Despite these physiological urgencies, the gym environment itself, what we call the *weight of the room*, acts as a key barrier to participation. Qualitative evidence indicates that women in gym settings often feel they are on display, which leads to a persistent sense of inadequacy and a perceived need to fight for space to be taken seriously (Cowley & Schneider, 2025). For a beginner, the sensory experience of a gym, the sights, sounds, and specific red flags encountered when searching for space, serves as a psychological barrier. There is an important gap in the literature about how perimenopausal beginners navigate these unspoken rules regarding how women should look or act while managing symptoms like joint pain or brain fog. This study aims to explore why some spaces foster "resistance towards gendered and appearance ideals" while others increase vulnerability (Cowley & Schneider, 2025). By examining these

perceptions, the research will help create a more inclusive social architecture for women in midlife and facilitate “empowerment through skill acquisition” (Cowley & Schneider, 2025)

The purpose of this narrative study is to uncover the experiences of perimenopausal women who practice strength training. At this stage in the research, strength training will generally be defined as any weight-lifting movement that overloads a muscle group. Perimenopausal women will generally be defined as a woman experiencing changes in her hormones due to the onset of menopause or a physiological body change, such as surgery. Workout space will be defined as the physical, social, and psychological components of the place where the women perform their strength training.

The central research question of this study is: How do perimenopausal women who strength train perceive the culture of the workout spaces they occupy? By exploring this question, the influence of the perceptions and expectations of a workout space can be used to understand motivators and roadblocks to women caring for their changing bodies. In turn, this will provide valuable insight into how strength training cultures impact women during the menopausal transition.

Methodology

This study followed a qualitative research approach. Denzin and Lincoln (1994) defined qualitative research as "attempting to make sense of, or interpret, phenomena in terms of the meanings people bring to them" (p. 2). We utilized this approach to explore the depth and nuance of participants' personal stories and observations. This is further substantiated by Kim's (2016) assertion that “qualitative research ... uses words rather than numbers in its analyses and focuses on understanding human action through interpretation rather than prediction and control” (p. 27).

This approach allowed for a flexible, conversational examination of lived experiences that could not be captured through quantitative measures alone.

Narrative Inquiry

In this study, we followed a narrative inquiry methodology that accessed participants' life experiences to understand multidimensional meanings of society, culture, human actions, and life (Leavy, 2009). Our study relied on in-depth interviews, with specific questions asking participants to share descriptive stories, to understand and describe women's experiences.

Theoretical Framework

In our study, the focus on the relationship between the environment and the individual was based on Social Cognitive Theory. In Social Cognitive Theory, a person makes things happen by their own actions, and Bandura (2001) refers to this as agency. Bandura (2001) states the "core features of agency enable people to play a part in their self-development, adaptation, and self-renewal with changing times" (p. 2). We examined how experiencing gym culture, compounded with the changes of perimenopause, affected the novice lifter's agency. In this context, the "changing times" reflected perimenopause and the gym culture.

Researchers Personal Stance

We are interested in how workout spaces can support the experiences of people who utilize them. The research team has a unique background to investigate this issue. Though two members are men, and one is a woman, we all have relevant expertise and interests. One of the male researchers is a physical education specialist with expertise in creating engaging and inclusive workout spaces. The other male researcher is a public health specialist with an interest in quality of life and accessibility of care. The female researcher is a strength training specialist with a passion for understanding and promoting strength training benefits. We acknowledge that

many people use workout spaces and have varying goals, and one subset of that population is perimenopausal women. The gaps in research to support the perimenopausal transition are staggering, given that most of the general population will either go through perimenopause or know someone who goes through that transition. We believe that a narrative approach to highlighting the stories of these women will be an effective form of building understanding and appreciation of their experiences.

Participants

Interviews were conducted with a purposeful sample (Creswell, 2007) of adult women currently in the perimenopausal transition. We included women who experienced this transition naturally, as well as those who experienced it as a result of a medical condition or surgery. Additionally, we looked for women who participate in strength training. Our definition of strength training was broad so that we would have access to a wider group of women. This less-restrictive definition allowed us to obtain a wide range of responses from women participating in a variety of strength training activities. These women lived in the United States, and most lived in the Northwest region of Colorado. We interviewed 7 women and expected that a sample of at least 6 women should provide saturation of the data (Creswell, 2007).

Participants were selected by posting flyers in strength training gyms and by sending emails to people known by the researchers. Sending direct emails was the most effective method of getting participants. Each researcher was able to perform at least two interviews. Women who were interested in participating were asked to provide additional contacts of women who might qualify for the study. This snowball type of sampling is dependent upon individuals who know other individuals that are information-rich in respect to the phenomenon (Creswell, 2007). The

snowball sampling was highly effective, as many perimenopausal women know other perimenopausal women who are interested in symptom mitigation.

Data Collection

The primary method of data collection was a semi-structured interview (Creswell, 2007) guide featuring open-ended questions, to explore the personal stories, feelings, and observations regarding the gym environment and its social norms. The interview script is attached (Appendix A). The interview was intended to be a flexible conversation where the participant described her lived experience in her own words. The guide was divided into three thematic focal areas:

1. **Entry into Weightlifting and Space:** Focused on the compatibility of strength training during mid-life and the sensory impressions of a gym.
2. **Perimenopause and Physical Agency:** Investigated how perimenopausal symptoms interacted with the structured culture of lifting.
3. **Gender Expression and Social Architecture:** Explored the unspoken rules of the gym and what self-empowerment looks like within that context.

Interviews were designed to last 45 to 60 minutes. The interviews took place as one-on-one sessions conducted via a secure online video platform or phone call. The interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim using available recording and transcription software. In addition to the interviews, all participants completed a brief demographic survey. This survey included questions about the participant's age, perimenopausal symptoms, and some aspects of their lifestyles.

Participants were contacted via email or promotional flyer. The flyer is attached (Appendix B). After initial contact, they were sent a consent form and were asked to schedule an

interview. Before starting the interview, the researcher read a brief consent script emphasizing that participation was voluntary and that the participant could withdraw at any time. By agreeing to move forward with the interview, the participant consented to be in the study.

Analysis of Data

The interview transcriptions were analyzed using narrative thematic analysis (Creswell, 2007) to identify recurring patterns and themes across participants' experiences. We looked for unique themes such as personal expectations for strength training, experiences in the workout space, and impact of workout space on perimenopause and vice versa. Additional themes were drawn from the interview data, following inductive analysis (LeCompte & Schensul, 1999). The themes were coded and analyzed for frequency.

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Findings

We interviewed seven participants, each of whom shared a unique story about their intersection of strength training and midlife. While their backgrounds varied, ranging from Susie, a mountain biker, to Casey, a competitive lifter, we identified five recurring themes that defined their collective experience.

Theme 1: Navigating Changing Bodies and Invisibility

The transition into perimenopause was described by participants not merely as a biological event, but as a psychological shift that altered their presence in the gym. **Susie** described a definitive moment of realization, noting, "It’s been like, OK, something happened... I’m like, Oh no, it’s hit. The change has hit to my body". This internal shift often led to a heightened, almost hyper-aware state of comparison. **Susie** admitted she frequently found herself "scanning the room and noticing other people’s body size," specifically wondering if the women she saw were also "perimenopausal".

For many, the physical changes led to a sense of disconnect between their effort and their appearance. **Tracey** poignantly noted that while she worked hard, the external perception of her body did not always match her discipline: "If you look at me physically, it looks like I eat bags

of Doritos every day, but actually, that's just because I'm older". **Nancy** shared that as her metabolism slowed, she noticed weight "sitting into my stomach," which served as the primary catalyst for her to seek out strength training to combat these "staggering" changes.

For **Stacy**, the emotional toll occasionally became a barrier to the space itself. She noted that on days when she felt "really negative about myself" and was in a "downward spiral," she found it "really hard... to get out and motivated to do it". Similarly, **Casey** expressed that her relationship with her body had become one of careful preservation, stating, "for my metabolism and my body, especially now that I'm getting older, I don't mess with it".

Theme 2: Social Belonging: The Spectrum of Tribe and Solitude

We found a significant "spatial paradox" in how these seven women utilized the social architecture of their gyms. **Casey** viewed the gym as a vital social anchor, describing lifting as a "together sport" where it was "always nice to be around people that have the same goals as you". **Susie** provided a vivid narrative of this "tribe" in action, describing her group as "very, very tight-knit". She shared that when "one of my classmates had brain surgery... we've taken meals to that person," illustrating that for many participants, the gym culture provided a deep sense of community that extended beyond the workout.

Ann echoed this sense of belonging, finding comfort in the "happy place" atmosphere of her gym, where an older gentleman would provide lighthearted entertainment with "Michael Jackson" impersonations. Conversely, other participants sought the gym as a site for "cognitive recovery" from the high mental load of midlife. **Betty** preferred her home workout space because it allowed her to "experiment or try something where I might look like an idiot" without the "intimidation" of being watched by others. **Stacy** represented this preference for autonomy as

well, finding empowerment in building a home space where she "could create something".

Despite these different approaches, all participants valued the simple act of being "greeted... just to acknowledge you as a person".

Theme 3: From Aesthetic "Shrinking" to Functional Longevity

A major cultural shift emerged regarding the "why" of strength training. Participants largely rejected the 1980s and 90s aesthetic standards of being "bone thin" or following "vodka and cigarette" diets. **Casey** noted that while some women today are still "chasing that" through modern means like "Ozempic," her own goals had evolved toward "functional longevity". She focused on heavy lifting as "preventative maintenance," even utilizing "estrogen gel to help prevent osteoporosis".

This sentiment was a core motivator across the group. **Ann** poignantly shared that while her 30s were about "what I looked like," her current focus was entirely different: "now, I want to be strong. I want to be able to move when I'm in my 80s and 90s". She referred to her own mother's decline as her "cautionary tale". **Stacy** echoed this functional mindset, viewing weights as a tool to "improve my mountain biking" rather than a means to achieve a certain look. **Nancy** reinforced this biological necessity, stating that women must "do strength training because... we're losing muscle mass".

Theme 4: Environmental Sensitivities as Cultural Signals

We observed that the physical state of the gym acted as a silent communicator of respect. **Casey** even applied "color theory" to her environment, noting that her gym's "red and black" scheme was "energizing" and helped her avoid "weird energy". **Susie** highlighted the importance of auditory cues, sharing that she enjoyed "singing along or humming along" to the music in her

classes. **Nancy** added that "hygiene is a must," closely observing whether staff were actively maintaining the space.

However, environmental "red flags" served as significant stressors. **Susie** expressed a "universal repulsion" for "gross, dirty, broken equipment," stating flatly, "I don't have time for that". She characterized the experience of an overcrowded gym as a "cat and mouse game" that felt "very stressful". **Tracey** was particularly sensitive to the temperature, noting that "with the heat, we get hot flashes like crazy". She explained that if a gym was not "nice and cool," she would often leave rather than attempt to work out through the discomfort.

Theme 5: Reclaiming the Weight Floor and Agency

Ultimately, we observed that mastering the workout space allowed these women to reclaim their "biological agency". **Betty** shared that building muscle was "very empowering" because it allowed her to "take control of something" rather than giving in to age-related decline. **Stacy** noted that while the weight floor was traditionally perceived as a masculine domain, she felt empowered when she was "surrounded by other women that are doing pretty badass stuff".

Susie reinforced this, noting that she was "not intimidated to get out there with men because there are a lot of women on the floor now". She specifically mentioned feeling safe and respected, stating, "I've never been hit on. I don't feel like anybody's gawking". **Casey** summarized the transformative power of the space, describing her routine as "exercise is medicine" and a "therapeutic start to my day". For **Nancy**, technical mastery was the key; she valued her trainer's help to "remember all of that information" about proper form, which allowed her to move from a "visitor" to an "owner" of her physical health. By prioritizing strength over aesthetics, these

seven women demonstrated that midlife is a period of building capability rather than winding down.

Conclusion

Reclaiming Agency in the Midlife Workout Space

The findings of this study demonstrate that for perimenopausal women, the workout space is a complex landscape where identity, biological transition, and social structures intersect. Participants' perceptions reveal that their participation in strength training is not merely a physical pursuit but a profound act of reclaiming agency during a significant life transition.

The Transformation of Purpose: From Aesthetic to Agentic

A primary conclusion of our research is a fundamental shift in the "why" and "how" of strength training. For this demographic, the gym has shifted from a place for aesthetic correction or weight loss to a sanctuary for functional longevity and "biological agency." Participants view strength training as "preventative maintenance", a proactive rebellion against the physical decline seen in previous generations. By prioritizing bone density and muscle preservation, these women move from "aesthetic shrinking" to "functional expansion." This shift suggests that the most successful workout cultures validate long-term health goals over short-term physical changes.

The Spatial Paradox: Social Tribe vs. Cognitive Solitude

The research highlights a significant "spatial paradox" in the social architecture of the gym. While the "tribe" or community aspect provides essential mental relief and a sense of belonging, there is an equally strong desire for solitude. For many, the gym serves as a site for "cognitive recovery" from the high mental load of midlife. The most effective cultures reduce

"gym friction" by offering a spectrum of belonging: fostering tight-knit support for those seeking connection while respecting the boundaries of those who use headphones and solitude to reset.

The conclusion is clear: women thrive in environments that allow them to choose between social support and sensory-focused solitude.

Environmental Design as a Signal of Respect

How women perceive gym culture is closely tied to the space's physical and organizational logic. Participants interpret factors such as cleanliness, equipment maintenance, and sensory cues as cultural signals. When a space is poorly maintained or overcrowded, it is perceived as a "stressor" or a "cat-and-mouse game" that adds to the existing cognitive load of perimenopause. Conversely, an organized, well-maintained environment signals professional respect. This indicates that a space's culture is not only defined by the people within it but also by how the environment accommodates the physical and mental sensitivities of its members.

Reclaiming the Weight Floor: Bridging the Knowledge Gap

A critical component of this study is navigating visibility and power, particularly on the weight floor. Traditionally perceived as a masculine or youth-centric domain, the weight floor remains a site of potential intimidation. However, the interviews suggest that the primary barrier to entry is often a "knowledge gap" rather than a lack of physical capability. As women gain technical mastery of machines, their perception shifts from being "visitors" to becoming "owners" of the space. Wearing activewear as "psychological armor" and seeking mentorship allow these women to reclaim their visibility and challenge age-related stereotypes in the gym.

Final Implications: A New Model of Inclusive Fitness

Ultimately, this study concludes that the fitness industry must move away from a "one-size-fits-all" model to better meet the specific needs of midlife women. The workout space for a perimenopausal woman is a site of active aging and reclamation. To foster a truly inclusive culture, fitness environments should:

- **Prioritize Functional Narratives:** Promote themes of functional longevity, bone health, and independence over traditional, aesthetics-based marketing.
- **Optimize the Sensory Environment:** Balance high-energy social spaces with opportunities for quiet, organized, and sensory-aware training.
- **Democratize Technical Knowledge:** Provide clear learning pathways and mentorship to de-gender and "de-age" the weight floor, moving technical mastery to the forefront of the member experience.

By recognizing the gym as a site of reclamation, this study shows that when perimenopausal women feel supported by the culture of their workout space, they do more than improve their physical health; they redefine their identity, demonstrating that midlife is a period of building strength rather than winding down.

Considerations

While this study offers deep insight into the lived experiences of perimenopausal women, several considerations apply to the scope of the research. First, our participants were already consistently engaged in strength training; therefore, the perspectives of those who feel completely excluded from or have dropped out of these spaces are not represented. Additionally, our sample was geographically concentrated in a specific region, which may reflect a local fitness culture that differs from those in more rural or diverse urban environments. Lastly, as a

qualitative study, these findings are intended to illuminate the depth of individual experiences rather than to provide statistical generalizations across all women in midlife.

Future Research

To build on these findings, future research should adopt a longitudinal approach, following women as they transition from perimenopause to post menopause to examine how their perceptions of strength and space evolve over time. Additionally, research comparing cultural perceptions of women in female-only versus co-ed strength training environments could provide valuable data for facility designers and trainers seeking to foster more inclusive settings.

Closing Statement

Ultimately, the voices in this study suggest that strength training in midlife is an act of reclamation, a way to ensure the future is defined by capability rather than decline. As one participant, **Amy**, poignantly shared about her drive to master the weight floor:

"In my 30s, it was about what I looked like... but now, I want to be strong. I want to be able to move when I'm in my 80s and 90s. This is my preventative maintenance."

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Appendices

A. Interview Questions

Consent statement: Start the interview with a statement reminding the participant that moving forward with the interview means she is giving her consent to participate in the study.

Reminder: it is allowable to deviate from this script to pursue topics and points of interest; can ask for more examples and stories to support specific points; embrace the narrative and conversational approach as this can lead to collection of more information

I. Basic Demographics

- How many times a week do you strength train?
- How long have you been strength training?
- What do you do for work?
- Could you describe the level of physicality required for your work?

I. The Entry into Strength Training & Workout Space

Focus: The intersection of mid-life transitions and the physical environment.

- **Can you tell me the story of how you first found your way into strength training?**
 - *Probe:* What was happening in your life, physically or emotionally, at that time that made this something you wanted to pursue?
- **Describe the process of finding your current workout space. What was that search like for you?**
 - *Probe:* What were the "red flags" in other gyms that made you keep looking

- **When you walk into your current gym, what are the first things you notice through your five senses?**
 - *Probe:* How do those specific sights or sounds influence your mindset before you even start the workout?

II. Peri-menopause & Physical Agency

Focus: Navigating a changing body within a structured lifting culture.

- **How has your relationship with your body evolved since you started strength training, particularly as you've noticed peri-menopausal changes?**
 - (Optional rephrase: How has your relationship with your body evolved since you started strength training? How has your relationship evolved with respect to perimenopausal changes?)
 - *Probe:* How does the gym environment affect you on days when you feel physically or emotionally "off" (e.g., fatigue, brain fog, or joint pain)?
- **In what ways does your workout space influence your willingness to attempt a heavy lift?**
 - *Probe:* Can you describe a time you felt particularly vulnerable in that space?

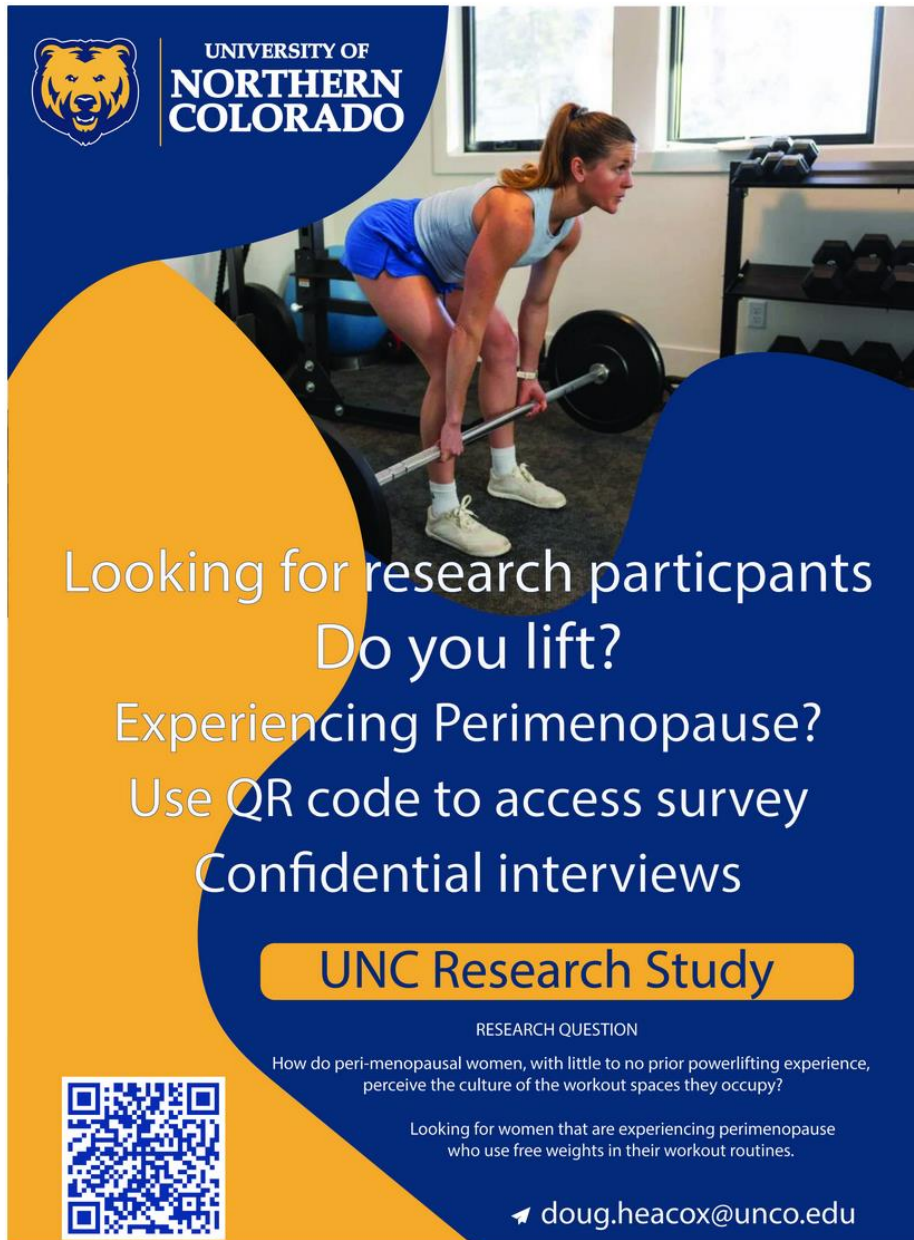
III. Gender Expression & Social Architecture

Focus: The "perceived culture" of the space and the participant's place within it.

- **How would you describe the "unspoken rules" of your gym regarding how women should look or act?**
 - *Probe:* Have you ever felt the need to "tone down" or "ramp up" your personality or appearance to fit in?

- **What does "empowerment" look like to you in the context of your lifting space?**
 - *Probe:* Is there a specific moment or interaction that made you feel like you truly belonged there?
- **If you could redesign your workout space to perfectly suit a woman in her 40s or 50s, what would that look and feel like?**

B. Promotional Flyer



 UNIVERSITY OF
**NORTHERN
COLORADO**

Looking for research participants
Do you lift?
Experiencing Perimenopause?
Use QR code to access survey
Confidential interviews

UNC Research Study

RESEARCH QUESTION

How do peri-menopausal women, with little to no prior powerlifting experience, perceive the culture of the workout spaces they occupy?

Looking for women that are experiencing perimenopause who use free weights in their workout routines.

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C. Journal Submission Guidelines

Target Journal: Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health (QRSEH)

The study is designed to align with the requirements for *Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health*. Key guidelines include:

- **Scope:** Research that advances understanding of sport and exercise through qualitative methods.
- **Length:** Original research articles should be no more than **8,000 words** including references.
- **Formatting:** All submissions must adhere to **APA 7th Edition** style.
- **Anonymization:** A blind title page and anonymized manuscript are required for the double-blind peer review process.
- **Ethical Approval:** A statement must be included confirming that the research was approved by an institutional review board (IRB).

Submission Guidelines:

<https://www.tandfonline.com/action/authorSubmission?show=instructions&journalCode=rqrs21#preparing-your-paper>

D. Codebook summary

Abbreviations: p = page; ts = time stamp; Inv = interview

Code Name	Code Description	Representative Data Excerpts	Data Source	Frequency
Social Component	The social aspects of working out came up for the three women, in different ways	1. "it's a together sport"; 2. "It's always nice to be around people that have the same goals as you"; 3. "I always make friends...we do things outside of the gym...one of my classmates had brain surgery this last year. We've taken meals to that person. We're a very, very tight-knit group"; 4. "I'd be working out regardless, but that one thing helps so much"	1. Inv 2, p4, ts 15:09; 2. Inv 2, p15, ts: 33:58; 3. Inv 3, p14, ts: 23:35; 4. Inv 3., p16, ts: 26:38	8
Lifting practice	Consistency over long periods is a trend for all three women	1. "I want to lift really heavy, but then I don't want to injure anything"; 2. "it's the one thing I enjoy, which is classes at gyms...Body Pump...I started that at least 25 years ago"; 3. "I've done lots of strength training, but I got really into mountain biking, and there was about a year where I was only mountain biking, but I know how valuable it is, so I have now put it back in my routine"	1. Inv 2, p 5, ts: 16:36; 2. Inv 3, p4, ts: 8:38; 3. Inv 1, p1, ts: 3:31	6
Gym characteristics	The women select different	1. "the environment we're in...it's serious competitors...it's very	1. Inv 2, p 6, ts 17:14; 2. Inv 2, p16, ts 35:15; 3.	5

	environments for training and look for different aspects in their spaces	different from a big box gym”; 2. “it’s like the energy off people...if you’re working out with bodybuilders, you’re like, OK. If I’m working out with a bunch of 17-year-olds because that’s the gym they go to, it’s not my favorite place to be”; 3. “classes are a must...I’m not going to go to a Planet Fitness because they don’t have classes. I want the option of both”	Inv 3, p 12, ts: 20:17	
Red Flags in a Gym	Poorly maintained facilities, cost, and distance are the biggest deterrents	1. “gross, dirty, broken equipment...I don’t have time for that”; 2. “cost, distance from my home...poorly kept...small size”; 3. “it’s just so darn busy at the times that I could go. I would say that’s the one biggest deterrent is that you are like playing this cat and mouse game the whole time you’re there and it feels very stressful”; 4. “the only reason I don’t go to a gym right now is cost and the fact that it is so convenient for me to workout at home”	1. Inv 2, p 8, ts 20:10; 2. Inv 3, p 13, ts: 20:59; 3. Inv 3, p24, ts: 39:20; 4. Inv 1, p3, ts: 11:36	5
Motivators	Mental health, physical appearance, and social aspects are main draws	1. “gained a bunch of weight, feeding my feelings...I need to change”; 2. “I love having a plan, having a goal, going through with it, and then planning another show...”; 3. “I was	1. Inv 2, p8, ts 20:52; 2. Inv 2, p 9, ts: 23:18; 3. Inv 1, p3, ts: 10:11	5

		really boy crazy for like the beginning of my life, so I thought that the gym was the best place to look at guys so that was a motivating factor for me...the is minimally relevant to me anymore...I have a decent amount of motivation because my priority is mountain biking and I know it will improve my mountain biking”		
Physical appearance	Emphasis on physical appearance differed for each woman	1. “I’m like hair, makeup nails, jewelry, like, that’s just how I am...this is my sport because you go backstage and everybody’s tan...hair’s done...the bathing suites are blingy...this is my sport”; 2. “I don’t really like to draw attention to myself whatsoever. If I was doing something untraditional, I would be in a far corner”	1. Inv 2, p 9 ts: 23:04; 2. Inv 1, p5, ts: 21:27	3
Gym Appearance and five senses	The importance of gym appearance varied based on what each woman was looking for in the gym space	1. “our gym is red and black...if you know color theory, like black and red are the most energizing ones...it’s like Feng shui...you walk in...and you don’t feel the weird energy”; 2. “another thing I really enjoy about the classes is the music set and singing along or humming along or whistling along...I	1. Inv 2, p10, ts: 24:00; 2. Inv 3, p17, ts: 28:50	3

		really like the music a lot”		
Demographics	The type of gym environment really depended on what gym the women selected and what they noticed around them	1. “it’s a lot of guys...I mean there’s a lot of females too...but it’s a lot a lot of guys”; 2. “I’m not intimidated to get out there with men because there are a lot of women on the floor now...and I’ve never been hit on. I don’t feel like anybody’s gawking”; 3. “mountain biking is my priority so I want to keep [weights] simple...and I’m in a small town and my students workout at the gym...I don’t particularly want to run into my students at the gym”; 4. “I feel like I’m surrounded by other women that are doing pretty badass stuff. So, then I’m not intimidated”	1. Inv 2, p13, ts 29:14; 2. Inv 3, p25, ts: 41:39; 3. Inv 1, p3, ts: 10:11; 4. Inv 1, p6, ts: 25:25	4
Relationship with body and perimenopause	Two women shared their menopausal symptoms and experiences and express concern over making changes at a time when physical fitness can’t be a priority	1. “for my metabolism and my body, especially now that I’m getting older, I don’t mess with it”; 2. “it’s been like, OK, something happened...I’m like, Oh no, it’s hit. The change has hit to my body and other symptoms”; 3. “I’m like gosh, I might have to change this up. I don’t know if this is effective anymore – this particular style - ...I don’t know if I’ll be successful at just getting out there because I won’t enjoy	1. Inv 2, p14, ts: 39:48; 2. Inv 3, p19, ts: 32:05; 3. Inv 3, p20, ts: 32:55; 4. Inv 1, p 3, ts: 14:26	4

		it as much”; 4. “if I feel really negative about myself and I’m kind of in a little bit of a downward spiral, it’s really hard for me to get out and motivated to do it”		
Perimenopause symptoms	Two women shared their symptoms which include hot flashes, weight gain, and concerns over osteoporosis	1. “estrogen gel to help prevent osteoporosis...I’m still having to prevent hot flashes...I get them more in the summer”; 2. “I don’t love the way I look”	1. Inv 2, p18, ts: 37:49; 2. Inv 3, p23, ts: 38:04	2
Cultural/physical Expectations of women	All three women notice the expectation to be thinner, but note this isn’t always reflected in other women at the gym	1. “bone thin...vodka and cigarette diet...now with Ozempic...women are chasing that again...like so skinny and like bones”; 2. “I find myself scanning the room and noticing other people’s body size...I wonder what she’s doing, you know, or she’s probably not, you know, perimenopausal”	1. Inv 2, p 20, ts: 40:58; 2. Inv 3, p23, ts: 38:04	1 3
Empowering aspects	For all three women, strength training was a mental health benefit and stress relief that supported their values and other areas of their	1. “exercise is medicine...it’s such a therapeutic start of my day”; 2. “I want to age well. I want to always be healthy. I want to live with my husband until we’re 85”; 3. “it’s my mental relief”; 4. “they greet you... just to acknowledge you as a person”; 5. “I was super into	1. Inv 2, p22, ts: 45:59; 2. Inv 2, p23, ts: 47:16; 3. Inv 3, p4, ts 7:44; 4. Inv 3, p30, ts: 48:55; 5. Inv 1, p 2, ts: 8:33; 6. Inv 1, p4, ts: 15:24	6

	lives	building my workout at home...made me feel like I could create something”; 6. “I like feeling strong. I like the commitment of it, so that makes me feel like I’m dedicating that time to myself”		
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Code Name	Code Description	Representative Data Excerpts	Data Source	Frequency
Preventative maintenance	Lifting to "get ahead" of aging, bone loss, and mobility decline.	1. "protect my bones, and prevent osteoporosis" 2. "window to kind of get ahead of what's coming" 3. "importance of building muscle and bone health" 4. "able to move when I'm in my 80s and 90s"	Inv 1 (p. 3, 10); Inv 2 (p. 2)	7
Zone-based intimidation	Perception of heavy lifting areas as "dudes" space or "younger" territory.	1. "the free weights was, like, all the dudes" 2. "mostly men... I just haven't gone over there" 3. "intimidating to me... they're all very young" 4. "raised eyebrows... at the heavier equipment"	Inv 1 (p. 12, 13); Inv 2 (p. 3)	7
Age-based dismissal	Symptoms being ignored or stereotyped by doctors or colleagues.	1. "welcome to getting old... life sucks" 2. "they called me their mom, basically" 3. "that happened to my mom" 4. "well, you're just welcome to getting old"	Inv 1 (p. 10); Inv 2 (p. 1)	6
Sensory inclusion	The need for "bright," "airy," and "clean" spaces to feel safe and comfortable.	1. "clean and bright and airy and... not creepy" 2. "visually, it was... a nice... gym" 3. "everything's really close together... not a lot of fan action" 4. "smelled clean... smelled, like... spa-like"	Inv 1 (p. 8, 9); Inv 2 (p. 2, 4)	7
Hormonal physical volatility	Managing unpredictable fatigue, joint pain, or night sweats.	1. "wake up sweating like crazy... I'm tired" 2. "weird joint pain... I was just falling apart" 3. "perimenopause... stepped that back... I feel weaker" 4. "lasted longer [soreness]"	Inv 1 (p. 10); Inv 2 (p. 2, 3)	7
Belonging mediators	Factors like "The Welcomer" or "Audience of One" that enable space use.	1. "He's sort of like the welcomer" 2. "I'm an audience of one" 3. "knowledge of how all the things are... work... to demystify" 4. "Brett... he's sort of like their mascot"	Inv 1 (p. 12, 14); Inv 2 (p. 2, 4)	7
Psychological masking	Deliberate choices in clothing or behavior to avoid gym attention.	1. "never wear anything, like, revealing" 2. "didn't want any... attention" 3. "just didn't want to engage at all" 4. "put my headphones in before I even walk in"	Inv 1 (p. 13); Inv 2 (p. 2)	5

Shared Codebook — (TC) & (NE)

Code Name	Code Description	Representative Data Excerpts	Data Source	Frequency
Preventative maintenance	Both women lift primarily to protect bones and muscle as they age. Perimenopause made this feel urgent, not optional.	TC: 1. "really important that I did weight training to try to keep my muscle" 2. "with weight loss surgery, you lose a lot of muscle mass if you're not careful" NE: 3. "we are losing muscle mass... it's strongly encouraged" 4. "really stressing the importance of women as we age that we want to do strength training"	TC (p. 3); NE (p. 2-3)	6
Sensory inclusion	Temperature, smell, and cleanliness were threshold conditions, not preferences. If the environment felt off, both women would leave before even starting.	TC: 1. "if it's not nice and cool in there, I might turn around and leave" 2. "I wipe the machines before I start" NE: 3. "cleanliness... hygiene is a must" 4. "I can smell if they just started mopped the floors or not"	TC (p. 5); NE (p. 6-7)	7
Hormonal physical volatility	Hot flashes, fatigue, and joint pain reduced both how often and how hard they trained. TC dropped from 7 days a week to barely 2; NE described the symptoms hitting physically, emotionally, and mentally.	TC: 1. "with the heat, we get hot flashes like crazy" 2. "when I was going 7 days a week... now I go barely 2 days" NE: 3. "the hot flashes... you feel a little bit more sluggish" 4. "missed menstrual cycles... emotionally, you're sensitive" 5. "your strength abilities change"	TC (p. 6-7); NE (p. 9)	7
Belonging mediators	Both had moments that made them feel they actually fit in the gym. TC found solidarity watching a struggling man show up every day; NE felt accepted because no one judged her for using lighter weights.	TC: 1. "this poor guy was working so hard... made me feel like I belonged there" 2. "felt like we all had a shared goal" NE: 3. "they have weights of all different sizes" 4. "you're not being judged or stared at because you're using lower weights"	TC (p. 9-10); NE (p. 12)	7
Zone-based intimidation / overcrowding	A crowded gym made both women hold back or leave. TC feared being watched during heavy lifts; NE worried about losing access to her machines.	TC: 1. "if there's a ton of people around, I'm probably not going to push myself very hard" 2. "don't want to be the lady that everyone is looking at who can't lift it" NE: 3. "if it's crowded and busy... that might deter me" 4. "am I gonna be able to get on my machines?"	TC (p. 7-8); NE (p. 8, 10)	7
Anti-clique gym selection	Both avoided gyms that felt too young, too fancy, or too status-driven. They wanted somewhere to blend in and just work.	TC: 1. "not one of those clicky gyms where everybody's really young" 2. "if they're really clicky gyms, I won't go" NE: 3. "I don't want to be at a gym where it's all high end and everybody has this certain type of attitude" 4. "judgment free zone"	TC (p. 4); NE (p. 6, 8)	7
Gym as purposeful space	Both treated the gym as a place to work, not socialize. Being intentional about why you are there mattered to both participants.	TC: 1. "just want to go to my workout and be left alone" 2. "women should go in there to work out instead of using it as a dating service" NE: 3. "I'm here to get my gym workout on. I'm not paying attention to that" 4. "don't hog up the machine... scrolling your phone"	TC (p. 4-5); NE (p. 6, 11)	7
Environmental empowerment	The right conditions: cool air, open machines, no judgment made both women feel capable of doing more. The space actively enabled or limited their performance.	TC: 1. "empowered when the space is conducive to getting a good workout" 2. "feel empowered to do longer workouts, come back more often, try heavier weights" NE: 3. "seeing other women in there lifting those weights too... that's empowerment" 4. "if they can do it, I can do it too"	TC (p. 9); NE (p. 12)	7
Age-inclusive gym redesign	Both wanted a gym built for perimenopause dedicated hours, right equipment, recovery options. TC: nap room. NE: juice bar + yoga.	TC: 1. "a gym that was just for us" 2. "hours that were just for perimenopause people" 3. "nap room... massage room, hot tub, sauna" NE: 4. "a juice bar... vitamin shots, supplements" 5. "the sauna... massages, facials, yoga classes"	TC (p. 10); NE (p. 13)	7